



K. R. DEEPAK

Young batters in Delhi often received high-quality equipment from him. Despite his busy international schedule, Virat stayed informed about the local scene and held the seniors of Delhi's past in high regard.

I was part of the organising committee for the inaugural Bishan Singh Bedi Lecture in 2017, where Virat was honoured by the legendary left-arm spinner. Stuck in traffic en route from Gurugram, he updated us every five minutes and was genuinely apologetic for arriving late. The audience loved it when he touched Bedi's feet on stage. Bedi was deeply moved too.

One incident still stands out. A young girl battling a serious illness wanted a video message from Virat. A friend connected her with me. When I asked Virat, he immediately recorded a heartfelt message. Not many sporting icons would do that today.

On another occasion, I asked Kapil Dev for a similar message for a friend critically ill with Covid in Hyderabad. The doctors weren't hopeful, but after seeing Kapil's

THERE WERE STRONG ECHOES OF SEHWAG IN VIRAT. BOTH BACKED THEMSELVES WITHOUT HESITATION. SEHWAG WAS A BIG INFLUENCE

video, the patient bounced back. Sporting heroes can sometimes be the best medicine. Virat and Kapil both proved that.

I'll never forget the exclusive interview Virat granted us in late 2015. He offered to come home for the session but I had to remind him of the security issues. "There will be a stampede if people got to know you are in my house," I joked. He laughed and instead invited me to his new home in Gurugram. The interview was unforgettable, made even better by a sumptuous